

PEACE BE WITH YOU
Pastors from Gurdaspur, Pathankot and Amritsar gather at Fatehgarh Churian for Samuel Masih Ministries' annual conference

perience of the presence of God. That is their main attraction.

Also, 'healing' can be a metaphor for a more holistic psychological and socio-economic restoration. This is not irrelevant, because the majority of the flock here come from Punjab's nine most exploited Dalit/ tribal communities, kept outside its arc of prosperity: Mazhabi Sikh-Balmiki, Sansi, Rai Sikh, Bawaria, Bazigar, Barad, Bangala, Gadhile and Nat. The reflex view these days sees conversions as 'illegal', but what exactly is illegitimate about a desire for the betterment of life-chances, an escape from caste stigma, a sense of community? "My children can now go to good schools, learn English and the pastor is helping me get a job at a mill. I never got so much affection from the Granthi sahib (local Sikh priest)," says Harinder Singh from Naraingarh, Amritsar, who claims to have come into the light of Jesus in 2018.

That's why even activist Manjit Singh Bhoma, sent by the BJP-backed Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee to counter "conversions" from Sikh families in the Majha belt, admits, "If these Christian groups give their children access to education, books or health facilities, Sikh institutions like the SGPC need to introspect what is wrong with that. It's very difficult to bring back those who have crossed over."

Even so, inevitably, the spectre of mass conversions has all sides agitated. Ministries peddling neo-Christianity are spread across Punjab's 23 districts, through the Majha and Doaba belts and the border areas of Ferozepur and Fazilka in Malwa have the highest concentration. There are no concrete figures, but one estimate pegs the overall number of pastors at an eye-catching 65,000.

Even the mainstream orders like the Catholic establishment are left bemused by this new surge—Pentecostalism is drawing their faithful away too. Are all of them converting, or merely seeking solace at one more place of worship—as Indians do in their eclectic religiosity? Perhaps both things are happening. Most of the pastors INDIA TODAY met claim they don't convert, only cure—and help people realise the "path of recourse from painful realities". But services offering *tauba*, or repentance, and *babtisma* (baptism) are common. Those who accept it, though still only a small percentage of Punjab's 29.6 million population, are a clearly growing cohort—and one that stands out in stark relief on the landscape.

Conversion is a legal right under the Indian Constitution, which is unambiguous about the freedom to profess or practise any religion. Recent years, though, have seen a spate of state-specific anti-conversion laws, hinging on the allegation of "force or inducement". Many of these have been challenged in court because "inducement" is all-too-widely defined. Punjab has no such law: Sikhism itself converts, and is doctrinally tolerant of all faiths. Its leadership is thus not exactly aligned with Hindutva's needs. In articulated terms, Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) president H.S. Dhami downplays the phenomenon. "They go to pastors as a quickfix for life's problems. Sooner or later, they will realise the truth and come back to their original faith," he told INDIA TODAY. A wariness is evident, though. The SGPC has launched 'counter' campaigns like Ghar Ghar Andar Dharmsaal, where volunteers go door-to-door to spread the word of Sikhism. And on September 5, at Anandpur Sahib, Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh stirred the pot by asking